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WBFB Western
Balkans
Fund

Supporting Common Projects



REPORT EU-WBFB JOINT ACTION

SECOND CALL FOR REGIONAL PROJECTS

PROJECT NAME:

**Support to the Promotion
of Civil Society Regional
Action in the Western
Balkans**

CN 2021/424-879



**Co-funded by
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About the Report

The WBF/EU Joint Action Report is compiled by the Western Balkans Fund, an international organization based in Tirana and recipient of EU Funds.

This report encompasses the period May 2022-January 24, focusing especially on the period January-November 23, when the Second Call for Proposals was implemented.

The report provides a comprehensive analysis of the activities, achievements, challenges, and impact of the joint action highlighting the efforts made by the WBF to foster regional cooperation, promote people-to-people exchange, and support projects that contribute to the social, cultural, and economic development of the Western Balkans.

WBF/EU Joint Action Report, outlines the successful initiation of the grant scheme support to third parties, which served as a catalyst for regional actors to implement regional actions in line with the WBF's objectives.

It highlights the diverse range of initiatives, including those focused on youth empowerment, educational exchange, cultural heritage preservation, environmental sustainability, and economic cooperation.

The report showcases the impact of these projects on regional integration, social cohesion, and cross-border collaboration.

REPORT EU-WBF JOINT ACTION

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Cover Page of the report of the First Call for Proposals.
For the online version, check our webpage
www.westernbalkansfund.org



Executive Director Murra, at the Awarding Ceremony of the 2nd Call for Proposals

Dear Partners, Friends, and Beneficiaries of the EU-WBF Joint Action,

We are happy to share with you the report of the largest Call ever launched by the Western Balkans Fund, which marks a period of unprecedented growth in the relevance and impact of the Fund.

Through this joint initiative, we supported Regional Initiatives of Civil Society Organizations (CSOs) and other stakeholders all over the Western Balkans Region. Less than half of all activities took place in the capital cities, with the rest spread across many regions, including remote areas where CSOs are not traditionally established.

In fact, we continued the tradition of the 1st Call for Proposals (1CfP) of the Joint Action, covering on average 85% of all the administrative divisions of the Western Balkans Region.

We are also proud to have constantly expanded our field of intervention. Despite maintaining our three key pillars: culture, education, and sustainable development, we focused more than ever on topics of great importance to the shared future of our Region, including human rights issues, green transition, innovation, etc.

During the 36 initially supported projects and three more selected from the reserve list during the implementation period

(due to the increased financial capabilities of the Fund), we successfully expanded people-to-people links and collaborative efforts in the Region.

In total, over 130 stakeholders benefited from the grants, and over one thousand partnerships were established for the application process.

Most importantly, the implementation of the many beautiful projects that we have undertaken made us stronger and enhanced our commitment to the European future of the Region.

Thanks to the important achievements and regional impact of our Action, we are delighted to share the good news of the continuation of the Joint Action for at least two more years.

After a pivotal 2023, during which all the Contracting Parties made significant steps towards full membership in the European Union, we believe that the time is ripe to turn our action into an active Hub that supports the regional ideas of CSOs throughout the year.

Once more, thank you for following us and most importantly, for believing in us and in our mission.

We look forward of many new achievements in the upcoming 2024-2025 period.

GJERGJ MURRA,
EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR, WBF



Fjordi Bisha, WBF-EU Joint Action Manager

Promoting regional cooperation is and remains a key component on EU's policy towards the Western Balkans. As a natural link in joining forces with the Western Balkans Fund, acknowledges more the dedication on supporting the Civil Society in the Western Balkans. Beyond providing direct financial support, WBF built knowledge, technical competence, and the capacity to successfully implement regional grant schemes and address the needs of the sector.

Through the Joint Action with EU, 1st and 2nd call, WBF managed to support 69 Regional Projects directly involving as Lead or partners, more than 250 organizations. Through these calls, WBF managed to provide greater access to funding for Civil Society and grass-root organizations to address the most burning issues that directly affect regional cooperation and good neighborly relations, including people-to-people links in the Western Balkans region.

FJORDI BISHA,
JOINT ACTION MANAGER

How did we get here?



EU-Western Balkans Leaders' Sofia Summit of 2018, dedicated to WB Region European perspective, development and cooperation, adopted a [Declaration](#) confirming EU's support for the region's European perspective.

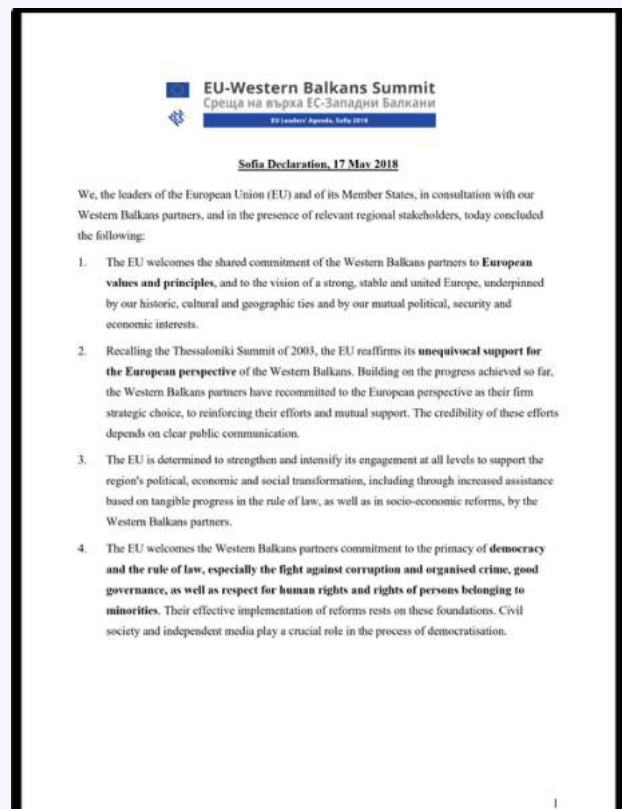
The Sofia Declaration was a significant milestone in the regional cooperation efforts of the Western Balkan contracting parties. In May 17.2018 at the European Union – Western Balkans Summit took place in Bulgaria. The Sofia Declaration deriving from this Summit aimed to strengthen the ties between the European Union and the Western Balkans and promote regional cooperation among the Western Balkan contracting parties themselves. One of the key outcomes of the Sofia Summit was the support given towards the Western Balkans Fund as a regional mechanism to support people-to-people connections and foster cooperation in the Western Balkans region.

More specifically, the leaders of the European Union and of its Member States, in consultation with Western Balkans partners, and in the presence of relevant regional stakeholders, concluded the following:

“

Supporting reconciliation and good neighbourly relations in the Western Balkans; more specifically promote deepening of links among civil societies of the Western Balkans, including through the support for the Western Balkans Fund projects.

Based on the commitments deriving from the Summit, the Fund strengthened the cooperation with European Union Commission with the purpose of supporting and promoting projects and initiatives that enhance regional cooperation, contribute to the sustainable development of the Western Balkans, and strengthen the bonds between the people of the region. It provides financial support for projects in various areas such as culture, education, scientific exchanges, sustainable development, and more.



In the years of existence, the Fund has demonstrated and proven itself as a unique cooperation mechanism and a good example to other initiatives of how to put the needs before differences in pursuit of a common, overarching goal. WBF has gone a long way and asserted itself as one of the most effective instruments encouraging cooperation in the region, including the most important element of cooperation - the people to people contact through personal relationships

H.E Ivica Dačić in 2018

SIGNING OF THE CONTRACT

In 2021, the Fund concluded the preparatory work with EU Commission by signing the contract for the WBF/EU Joint Action to foster regional cooperation and contribute to the development of the Western Balkans.

PROJECT UNIT

Upon signing the contract for the Joint Action, the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) made a significant step in the collaboration with EU Commission to implement the action by establishing the project unit.

The team is responsible for managing and overseeing the implementation of the action under the WBF/EU partnership. The project unit comprises professionals with expertise in project management, monitoring and evaluation, finance, and relevant thematic areas. This team is responsible for coordinating and executing the activities outlined in the joint action.

Moreover, the project unit manages the financial and human resources and monitors budget utilization, tracks expenditures, and ensures that resources are allocated efficiently to achieve project goals. Including the establishment of monitoring and evaluation mechanisms to assess action progress, measure results, and identify areas for improvement. WBF has created a culture of knowledge sharing where the project unit is responsible to facilitate knowledge sharing among team members, partners, and stakeholders.



The joint action of the European Union and Western Balkans Fund serves the European Union agenda in the Western Balkans and reflects our values and aspirations. We expect this cooperation to enable the grassroots organisation to engage in regional cooperation, positively impact good neighbourly relations and reconciliation, and have a greater role in the accession reforming processes. H.E Luigi Soreca, EU Delegation to Tirana at the inaugural ceremony, November 2022

“The region is changing, and what was once impossible is becoming a reality. That shows just how much we can achieve if we opt to work together”

Olta Xhaçka, Minister of Foreign Affairs and Europe of Albania

KICK OFF MEETING

In November 23. 2021, the WBF/EU Joint Action held the Kick Off Meeting that marked the beginning of a collaborative effort between the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) and the European Union (EU) Commission to jointly support regional initiatives and projects in the Western Balkans.

This meeting brought together representatives from both organizations, diplomatic corps in Tirana, as well as relevant stakeholders, to lay the groundwork for successful cooperation and discuss the objectives, strategies, and expected outcomes of the joint action. This meeting provided great opportunity to highlight the importance of regional cooperation, the role of the

WBF and the EU in supporting the Western Balkans, and the specific goals of the joint action.

The participants had the opportunity to learn and discuss the thematic areas that will be the focus of the joint action. These areas included cultural cooperation, education and scientific exchanges, sustainable development, social inclusion, economic growth, or other relevant topics. Also, the Kick Off Meeting allowed the identification and coordination of resources and expertise from both the WBF and the EU Commission since it provided a platform for discussing how the two organizations can leverage their respective strengths and capacities to achieve common objectives

GRANT SCHEME

The scheme plays a crucial role in providing financial support to third parties for implementing projects that contribute to regional cooperation, development, and progress in the Western Balkans. Within the framework of the WBF/EU Joint Action, WBF implements grant scheme that support innovative and impactful regional projects that foster regional cooperation, contribute to sustainable development, and address key societal challenges in the Western Balkans. Through the mechanism of grant scheme, the WBF provides opportunities for civil society organizations to access funding and collaborate with regional and



Nevertheless, this meeting facilitated networking and collaboration among participants, including representatives from civil society organizations, government entities, academia, and other relevant stakeholders. It encouraged the formation of partnerships and the exchange of knowledge and best practices.

23 November 2021, the kick-off ceremony of the EU-WBF Joint Action. First left, EU Ambassador to Tirana, H.E. Luigi Soreca. Second left, Minister of Foreign Affairs and Europe of Albania, H.E. Olta Xhaçka

international partners to drive positive change in the region. By strategically investing in projects, WBF strengthens its impact in the areas linked to regional cooperation and reconciliation.

2nd Call of the Join Action



Awarding Ceremony of the 2nd Call for Proposals

In May 2022, one month from the start of the implementation phase of the 1st Call for Proposals, reported in our previous “First Call for Proposals Report”, the Western Balkans Fund launched the Second Call for Proposals of the Joint Action.

The Call remained open until July 8, attracting 367 lead applicants and involving over a thousand Civil Society Organisations in the WB Region. Thanks to the European Union financial support, the 2 CfP is the largest CfP ever launched by the WBF, with a fund of 500.000 Euros supporting best regional ideas. 36 project, shared equally between the six Contracting Parties benefited up to 15.000 Euros in funding.

Thanks to added financial capabilities of the Fund, three more projects on the reserve list were included in a later phase.

Info Session – Similarly to the previous 1 CfP, the WBF team embarked on a regional tour, stopping at 12 locations, 2 per Contracting Party. From May 30 to June 10 2022, WBF teams visited Belgrade, Nis, Podgorica, Niksic, Prishtina, Mitrovica, Skopje, Tetovo, Sarajevo, Tuzla, Tirana and Shkodra.

Info Days – Under the 2nd Call for Proposals, WBF piloted Info Days for the first time. Under this new format, the Secretariat spread in geographical locations selected in accordance with desk research. Banja Luka, Zenica, Mostar, Novi Sad and Kragujevac were the recipient cities of 2 CfP Info Days.

Mentorship Sessions – Western Balkans Fund allowed anyone to reach us out remotely in every official language in the Region. To better accommodate the needs of the Civil Society Organisations and other regional stakeholders, on 22-23 June, Mentorship Sessions in Bosnian, Croatian, Serbian, Montenegrin, Albanian, Macedonian, and English provided additional support for 161 enrolled participants.

Following the Evaluation Process in September-November 2022, thirty-six grants were awarded, with 127 Civil Society Organisations as direct beneficiaries, in December 2022. The grants, which are divided equally between the Contracting Parties of the Western Balkan Region, aim to improve cooperation and enhance reconciliation at the regional level.

Culture, education, science and research, sustainable development, environmental issues, and women empowerment are the main fields of intervention of the awarded grants. The winners of the grants participated in the Awarding Ceremony in Tirana in December. Parallely, a workshop provided to the grantees a tailor-made training on contractual, financial, reporting, monitoring and visibility requirements. Moreover, during the implementation of the project, all grantees received at least one visit from our team members, facilitating further the implementation of the projects.

In October and November, all the projects concluded implementation and started the reporting phase. By the end of 2023, the 2nd Call for Proposals of the Joint Action successfully completed.



Empowering action, the transformative value of our projects

WBF continued to empower civil society organizations, public institutions, non-governmental organizations, professional associations, and all other stakeholders through its 2nd Call for Proposals.

These projects have brought about positive change, significantly impacting sustainable growth in the Balkan region.

Our projects vividly showcase the transformative impact that our grantees have had, catalyzing progress in people-to-people connections, regional cooperation, and reconciliation.

Boosting internal capacities and visibility of our grantees and their projects

Our grantees have reported that, due to WBF support, they have increased their visibility and raised awareness about common issues and challenges.

Additionally, they were able to connect with like-minded organizations and donors.



MEL Officer, Uros Citakovic (L) and WBF Senior Program Manager, Dafina Beqiri, present during an info session

Through collaboration with local stakeholders, we have supported more than 140 qualitative partnerships spanning different geographical locations, marked by a high intensity of knowledge transfer.

This has played a crucial role in fostering regional cooperation in culture, education, and sustainable development.



Pictures from different projects
 Top Left: Visiting the Municipality of Kragujevac
 Top Right: A large event on women empowerment held in Pristina
 Bottom Left: Visiting the famous Sarena Mosque in Tetovo
 Bottom Right: Conference on education in Podgorica

Furthermore, our grantees have reported an enhancement of their internal capacities in project management, financial reporting, and monitoring and evaluation of their final beneficiaries, all attributed to WBF support.

An impressive 9 out of 10 grantees report that their experience with WBF has motivated and equipped them to

continue playing an active role in regional cooperation.

Additionally, 4 out of 5 grantees report that, following the successful implementation of projects, they are not only capable of forging but also sustaining regional partnerships, engaging with relevant stakeholders in a meaningful way.

Investing in Education and Scientific exchange

Education and scientific exchange constitute one of the main pillars of our mission.

Thirty-five percent of all supported projects within the 5th Call for Proposals focused on empowering human capital, including youngsters, students, and professionals through the organization of trainings, workshops, study visits exchange of best practices, and overall enhancement of educational and scientific infrastructure.

Together with our grantees we have positively impacted the lives of more than 1700 students and young professionals.

The improvement in media literacy rates, the increase in levels of a more inclusive society addressing the education of people with disabilities and enabling youngsters from marginalized groups to have access to quality education reflect our unwavering dedication to building a knowledgeable and skilled region full of potential.

Fostering cultural cooperation and regional synergies

Two out of five projects supported within the 5th CfP promoted social cohesion and cultural exchange

Through the lens of these projects, the emphasis on social cohesion and cultural exchange has resulted in tangible shifts in attitudes among participants.

Individuals involved in those community-driven projects have experienced a recorded change in their perception of other regional cultures and shared challenges.

This change in attitude has been accompanied by a heightened motivation to continue engaging in regional cooperation with peers and colleagues.

By supporting projects at the local level, WBF has not only united diverse communities but has also strengthened societal bonds within the Western Balkans.

The dedication to preserving and celebrating the rich cultural diversity of the Western Balkans has not only enriched the lives of individuals involved but has also contributed to the broader goal of building a more interconnected and harmonious region.

In essence, cultural cooperation projects have proven to be catalysts for positive change, creating a lasting impact on social inclusion and regional cooperation.

Championing Sustainable development

WBF has been championing sustainable development through a focus on promoting green initiatives, new solutions and new technologies, and raising awareness of pressing environmental challenges.

One out of every three supported projects dealt with sustainable development or utilized multisectoral approaches to address far-reaching regional challenges.

Our commitment to promoting these cross-cutting issues is evident in the allocation of resources toward efforts that adopt sustainable practices, with an average allocated amount of more than 14,000 EUR per project proposal.

Our grantees have reported that, due to their previous positive experiences with project partners and target groups, there is significant potential for future cooperation in this field.



In "Music we Trust" - A project implemented in Tirana, Skopje and Pozarevac

In the Spotlight

Enhancing the visibility of the Joint Action

Promoting Regional Cooperation is a crucial component of our mission. Thanks to work initiated with the launch of the action in November 2021, the Second Call for Proposals enjoyed a hugely important boost of visibility.

In regard to the internal communication channels, in over 300 posts and updates on the official webpage and the dedicated website of the action, the Western Balkans Fund has always promoted and closely monitored the implementation of the funded projects, multiplying the effects of every single project.

The updates and posts about the many Conferences, Events, Workshops, Summer Schools, Artistic Performances, and more have been randomly picked up by mainstream media, generating an important outreach for the Joint Action.

On the website, information about the 2 CfP has been seen by 43 thousand unique users since May 20, 2022, the day the Call was declared open.

In Social Media, the organic reach of the Call for Proposals has surpassed a remarkable reach of 1 million accounts. Combined with the paid advertising, the campaign has already generated a reach of over 1.3 million.

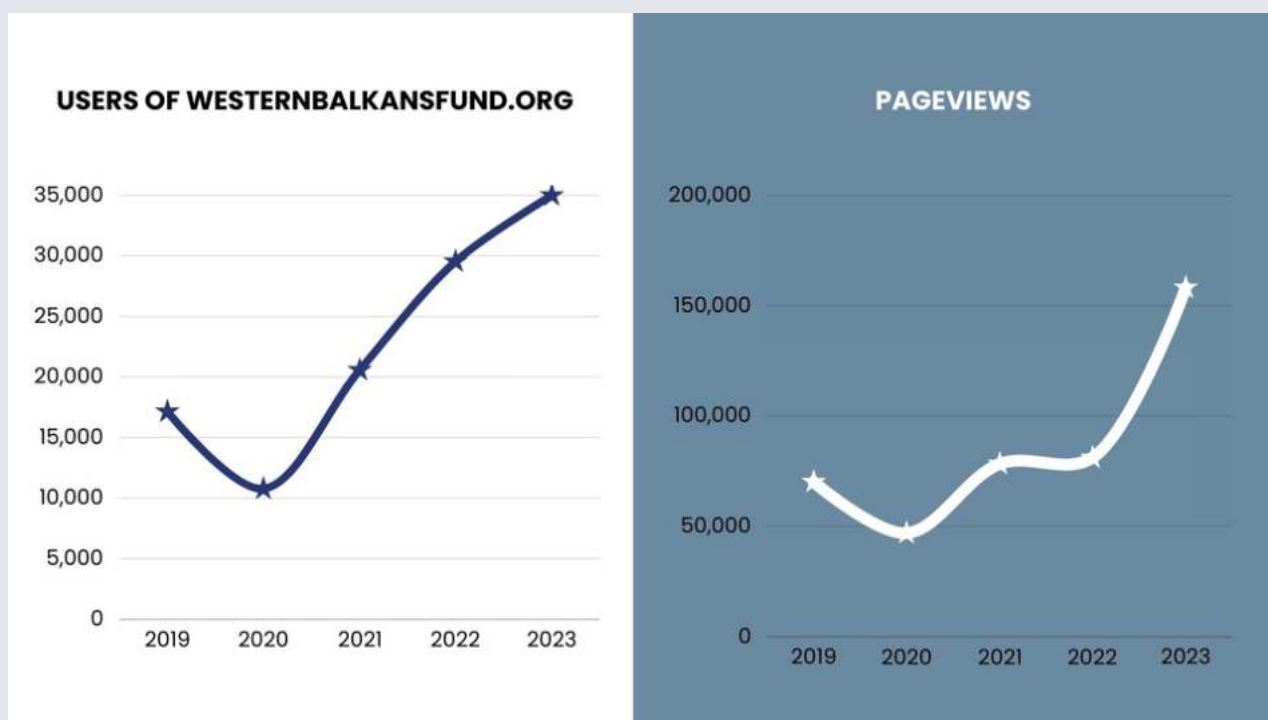


vezuje Zapadni Balkan starim ćirnim prugama
Sarajeva, do Herceg Novog. Uvezala bi rute kojima je i

Radio Free Europe reports on the Joint Action

In addition to the content shared through the communication channels, the Western Balkans Fund team has engaged with many stakeholders on the ground. This has been done through representational visits and physical mentoring of every single project supported.

All of the joint efforts of the team have increased cooperation between Regional Stakeholders, increasing the understanding of the EU-driven integration process and the benefits of cooperation at large scale.



Users and Pageviews of the Western Balkans Fund are constantly increasing

85%

Applicants and participants of the Call for Proposals were uniquely diverse in terms of geographical diversity. The Call successfully generated interest in more than 100 locations, covering the absolute majority of the Western Balkans administrative territory.



Joint Action attracts important visibility in social media. Besides Facebook and Instagram, the two socials of choice of WBF, we are also present in Twitter, Youtube, LinkedIn and Threads



Supporting the growth of grassroots organisations

From the WBF-Partnership Workshop of the 2CfP

The WBF's main target audience for regional cooperation projects are the grassroots organizations, that in the 1st and 2nd Call for Proposals of the Joint Actions have represented over 1/3 of the number of the applicants.

To us, grassroots organizations are defined as national or regional entities that make a long-term personal commitment to communities embedded in the local social networks having the unique ability to bridge the actions within the local actors/stakeholders and institutions.

The EU/WBF Joint Action project despite the sub-awarding grants to the regional cooperation projects

focused and dedicated significant energies/efforts and day-to-day mentorship and support to the awarded grantees as an essential component of Project Cycle Management and mutual accountability

In addition to live monitoring and mentoring sessions, during the 2nd Call of Proposals, the regional grassroots organizations supported by WBF exercised the Grantee Portal within OGMS to report live on the implementation of project activities. This was the very first time the awarded grantees had the chance to experience the OGMS as a reliable system for importing all the relevant data according to the approved budget and project.

Online Grant Management System (OGMS) served the applicants/grantees under the 2nd Call for Proposals not just in the application process but also in the implementation, monitoring, and reporting stages making it possible to strengthen their capacities and bring to them an added value in self-grow and enhancing knowledge in digitalization skills and challenges while participating in contractual terms with a Donor such as European Union.

Supporting grassroots organizations with this EU/WBF Joint Action for WBF has been pivotal to ensuring the sound financial management and adequate controls while implementing IPA EU-funded projects for Civil Society Organizations in the Western Balkans.

The Grantee Portal within OGMS enabled the awarded grantees to record every single activity during the implementation which later proved to be very beneficial before the reporting period since all the data regarding expenses incurred were already in the system and that helped and facilitated the process of preparation and submission of Financial Report with supporting documentation to WBF respective CP Program Managers.

As part of the awarding ceremony of the EU/WBF Joint Action, the WBF organized a Partnership Workshop for all awarded regional cooperation projects aiming to foster and enhance their capacities in project management by introducing tips and practices on financial, procurement, and visibility guidelines. Afterward, the online mentorship sessions were held with all awarded grantees.

The overall objective of the Financial and Procurement Guidelines was to provide WBF grantees with basic principles and procedures for the establishment and implementation of the project budget and the control of project finances.

These principles are related to co-financing, in-kind contributions, prohibition of double financing and profit rule, financial responsibility, budget reallocations, verification and eligibility of costs, record keeping, and procurement practices

This approach did not stop there since the WBF-designated program managers continued with mentoring and monitoring activities in the Region by conducting on-spot visits to the grantees during the period of project main events to get familiar with the project progress and support the project team in any direction prior to the reporting phase of the project.

All these features and tools were introduced aiming to ensure that grantees have the potential to learn and implement projects according to Donor rules and regulations.

The impact and reflection session of this beneficial learning mechanism was evident in the Two-Day Fina Partnership Workshop recently organized by WBF in Durres with all the grantees of the EU/WBF Joint Action who expressed their gratitude towards WBF, and knowledge gained through this regional cooperation projects supported financially by WBF.

Overall, the live and feedback process established with the use of the OGMS, as well as the approach to follow and mentor all the grantees, provided long-lasting benefits to the great majority of the newly established applicants.

What's next for the CSOs of our Region



Family picture of the Joint WBF-EU TACSO workshop in Durrës

From 5-7 December, together with over 50 grantees of the 1st and 2nd Call for Proposals, in the city of Durrës, in cooperation with EU TACSO, we organized a large 3-days workshop focusing on building capacities, partnerships, and sustainability in the Western Balkans Region.

At the closing event, Dafina Beqiri, WBF Senior Program Manager, set the tone by emphasizing the importance of donors allocating more funds to enhance partnerships. She underscored the value of workshops like this for all participants.

Jelena Pajovic van Reenen, EU TACSO expert, was asked to elaborate on specific insights regarding how to ensure funds are dedicated to activities that aim to increase cooperation.

“To build a successful partnership, you need trustworthy partners who understand their roles. From what we heard yesterday, there is a need to insist on sustainability within existing grant calls. Organizations should describe how they will continue their activities after the funding ends, emphasizing investment in long-term impact”, she responded.

Ms Beqiri then turned to Andreja Tonc, who highlighted the importance of involving project partners from the beginning to the end for a full Project Cycle Management (PCM).

She also stressed the significance of partners participating in training sessions organized by different donors to collectively increase capacities.

Regarding small-budget projects, Andreja mentioned that initiatives are sometimes overlooked, and stakeholders may not take them seriously due to limited funds. Dafina asked for practical implementation examples and effective tools or programs for building skills.

“We have a component for capacity building in addition to people-to-people events. You can expect an open call next year for the submission of people-to-people events. Subscribe to our webpage for updates on accessible online activities, events, and training”, added.

Additionally, Ms Tonc emphasized the importance of stakeholder involvement throughout the PCM, encouraging a thorough analysis of stakeholders at the project's beginning and continuous assessment of their importance.

Natasha Nazari, again from EU TACSO underlined: “We have guidelines aligned with EU standards for civil society. Now, we are in the process of evaluating indicators of Civil Society Organisations in the Region. CSOs have the chance to contribute, and I invite everyone to share in focus group consultations to strengthen our collective impact.”

Fjordi Bisha, our WBF-EU Joint Action Manager, concluded the panel by underscoring: “Partnership was a keyword of this workshop, with community support, elevating knowledge, and bringing together diversity as key pillars. Community support, not only for CSOs but also for WBF, is crucial for sustainability. Bringing together diversity, both in partnerships and ideas, enhances regional cooperation. Elevating knowledge has a reciprocal effect, enabling organizations to better understand their communities and plan for the future.”

In summary, the conference highlighted the need for sustainable practices, thorough stakeholder analysis, and ongoing collaboration to achieve long-term impact in the region.



Final Panel of the Workshop. From Left to Right: Dafina Beqiri, Jelena Pajovic van Reenen, Andreja Tonc, Natasha Mazari and Fjordi Bisha

**WBF-TACSO
Joint Workshop**

**OF THE CHAMPIONS
COOPERATION IN THE V**

Dur... mber 2023

**REGIONAL
ADVANCEMENT OF THE
COOPERATION**

**MOVE Grants
Projects as per
area of
intervention**

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**WBF-TACSO
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WBF

EUWBF

**WBF-TACSO
Joint Workshop**

The collage consists of 12 photographs arranged in a grid-like fashion, showcasing various moments from the WBF-TACSO Joint Workshop. The images include:

- A large group of people seated at long tables in a rustic hall with wooden beams and large windows.
- A man in a suit writing on a whiteboard with handwritten notes under the heading "GRASSROOTS".
- A man in a suit speaking at a podium with a microphone, with a European Union flag in the background.
- A woman with blonde hair and glasses speaking into a microphone, with a European Union flag in the background.
- A man in a suit speaking at a podium with a microphone, with a European Union flag in the background.
- A woman with long brown hair speaking into a microphone, with a European Union flag in the background.
- A group of people standing together, with a European Union flag in the background.
- A man in a suit speaking at a podium with a microphone, with a European Union flag in the background.
- A group of people standing together, with a European Union flag in the background.
- A man in a suit speaking at a podium with a microphone, with a European Union flag in the background.
- A group of people standing together, with a European Union flag in the background.
- A man in a suit speaking at a podium with a microphone, with a European Union flag in the background.

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**WBF-TACSO
Joint Workshop**

OF THE CHAMPIONS OF
COOPERATION IN THE V

During November 2023

EU-WBF JOINT ACTION IN THE FRAME OF THE CONTRACT "SUPPORT TO THE WESTERN BALKAN COUNTRIES"

REGIONAL
ADVANCEMENT
OF THE
COOPERATION

EU-WBF JOINT ACTION IN THE FRAME OF THE CONTRACT "SUPPORT TO THE WESTERN BALKAN COUNTRIES"

MOVE Grants
Projects as per area of intervention (applications)

EU-WBF JOINT ACTION IN THE FRAME OF THE CONTRACT "SUPPORT TO THE WESTERN BALKAN COUNTRIES"

EU-WBF JOINT ACTION IN THE FRAME OF THE CONTRACT "SUPPORT TO THE WESTERN BALKAN COUNTRIES"

**WBF-TACSO
Joint Workshop**

The collage consists of 12 photographs arranged in a grid-like fashion, showcasing various moments from the WBF-TACSO Joint Workshop. The top-left photo shows a large group of people seated at long tables in a bright, modern meeting room with large windows. The top-right photo shows a man in a suit writing on a whiteboard titled 'GRASSROOTS', which lists various topics like 'SUSTAINABILITY', 'WELLBEING', and 'SOCIAL INCLUSION'. The middle-left photo shows a man in a blue shirt speaking at a podium with EU and Finnish flags in the background. The middle-right photo shows a woman in a black top and floral scarf speaking at a podium. The bottom-left photo shows a woman in a black top and white shirt speaking at a podium. The bottom-right photo shows a group of people sitting around a table, engaged in a discussion. Other photos show individuals speaking at podiums, groups of people standing together, and a man writing on a whiteboard. The overall theme is professional collaboration and discussion.

**WBF-TACSO
Joint Workshop**

**OF THE CHAMPIONS
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**REGIONAL
ADVANCEMENT OF THE
COOPERATION**

**MOVE Grants
Projects as per
area of
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(applications)**

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**WBF-TACSO
Joint Workshop**

OF THE CHAMPIONS OF
COOPERATION IN THE V

During November 2023

EU-WBF JOINT ACTION IN THE FRAME OF THE CONTRACT "SUPPORT TO THE WESTERN BALKAN PARTNERSHIP FOR GROWTH AND INNOVATION"

REGIONAL
ADVANCEMENT
OF THE
COOPERATION

EU-WBF JOINT ACTION IN THE FRAME OF THE CONTRACT "SUPPORT TO THE WESTERN BALKAN PARTNERSHIP FOR GROWTH AND INNOVATION"

MOVE Grants
Projects as per area of intervention (applications)

EU-WBF JOINT ACTION IN THE FRAME OF THE CONTRACT "SUPPORT TO THE WESTERN BALKAN PARTNERSHIP FOR GROWTH AND INNOVATION"

EU-WBF JOINT ACTION IN THE FRAME OF THE CONTRACT "SUPPORT TO THE WESTERN BALKAN PARTNERSHIP FOR GROWTH AND INNOVATION"

WBF at previous EU TACSO workshops



Join Action in Numbers

24

Regional Info Sessions

69

Awarded Grants

264

Stakeholders involved

375

Eligible Applications

714

Total Applications

2.000

Total of the partnerships established

15.000

Maximum amount of a Single Grant

900.000

Euros in Grants for this action

62%

Share of EU funding to this Action

1.479.372

Social Media Reach

3.200.000

Million Euros requested by applicants from the 2 CfP

7.400.000

Euros, the total amount of funding requested from all the applicants

Joint Action 2nd Call for Proposals Catalogue

The following is a detailed list of all the projects funded under the Second Call of the Joint Action, implemented from January to November 2023.

To avoid potential sensitivities, we have decided to name all the locations where the action has taken place in the native/official language of the Contracting Parties

Accursed Mountains Crossorder Science Classroom



Lead Applicant
NGO Green Home | **Podgorica**

Partners
Environmentally Responsible Action |
Prishtinë
Institute for Nature Conservation in Albania |
Tiranë

The seven-day camp hosted 24 attendees from diverse regions of three of the Contracting Parties of the Western Balkans Fund Beyond exploring nature, participants shared insights on various everyday life subjects.

The camp provided a platform for individuals passionate about similar topics, such as plant life, Balkan lynx movements, bears, and bird migrations, to connect and exchange ideas.

Discussions also revolved around kick-starting initiatives at the faculty level for more frequent exchanges. Additionally, they explored options for regular camps and prepared project proposals for future endeavors.

Advancing regional cooperation and EU integration through the Think Balkan's initiative



Lead Applicant

Institute for Democracy "Societas Civilis"
| **Skopje**

Partners

Evropski pokret u Srbiji (EPuS)/ European Movement Serbia | **Beograd**
Albanian Institute for International Studies | **Tiranë**

The face-to-face encounters facilitated regional discussions, forging enduring bonds and enriching the pool of shared knowledge and insights.

Through in-depth discussions with civil servants and public institutions, researchers gained practical insights that complemented their theoretical understanding.

The direct engagement allowed for a more comprehensive understanding of the operational aspects of EU integration, enhancing the project's depth and reinforcing the interdisciplinary approach pivotal to achieving our project's objectives."

Astrotourism - fostering STEM and SDG!

The project significantly impacted the partners current and future capabilities by enhancing mutual recognition of their activities, target groups, capacities, and commitments within their respective countries.

This recognition has laid the foundation for future collaborative endeavors. Moreover, the project's influence extended to the new generations, establishing a stable and clear framework for the future.

All of this creates the basis for turning space exploration in a thriving sector, which can potentially benefit all the Contracting Parties of the Western Balkans Fund.



Lead Applicant

StemLAB | **Tetovo**

Partners

Qendra Inovative Kualifikuese Edu Act Albania | **Tiranë**
Universi | **Prishtinë**
STEAM Academy | **Sarajevo**

ARYSE



Lead Applicant

NVO Juventas | **Podgorica**

Partners

Prevent | **Novi Sad**

NGO Labyrinth | **Prishtinë**

Initiative for Social Change ARSIS | **Tiranë**

HOPS - Healthy Option Project | **Skopje**

The Aryse project was implemented by a group called the ARYSE Network, the first group in the Balkans to support young people at risk. It started in 2016 as part of a bigger project supported by the EU.

Six different groups were part of this, with NGO Juventas from Montenegro leading the way. Other groups from all of the Contracting Parties, plus Germany cooperated.

The ARYSE Network's main goal was to help young people at risk fit in better in the region. They wanted to do this by making sure groups that help young people were strong, that different countries worked together, and that they could ask for fair treatment in education, jobs, and the law. They aimed to help these young people take part in decisions that affect them and make things better for them in the Balkans.

Bioinforming the youth

The project helped in getting different stakeholders in the Western Balkans to cooperate better. In the project framework, meetings for students were held in Novi Sad and Skopje. Students from different Contracting Parties got together to learn about bioinformatics. It was like a big team where everyone worked and learned together.

A key milestone was an online event called a Biohackathon. Young People from all the Western Balkan joined.

They worked in teams to use computers to predict how plants fight diseases. This teamwork made them friends and helped them trust each other more. It was great to see everyone getting along well.

This project made a difference by bringing students together and helping them work as one team. It showed that when people from different places work together, they can achieve a lot and become good friends.



Lead Applicant

NVO Bioinformatika | **Herceg Novi**

Partners

EduSmart | **Beograd**

The Higher Education Technical School of Professional Studies in Novi Sad | **Novi Sad**

Mother Teresa University | **Skopje**

Connecting Makerspaces in the Western Balkans Region



Lead Applicant

Association 'Digital Fabrication Laboratory' | **Sarajevo**

Partners

NFoster Association – Stip | **Štip**
Innovation business center Zlatibor | **Zlatibor**
Science Technology park Čačak | **Čačak**

The project supported workshops across partner organization sites, fostering mutual understanding, idea exchange, and strategy sharing. These sessions served as spaces for networking, forging partnerships, aligning common interests, and spreading innovative ideas.

The culmination of these efforts is maker.ba, a pioneering regional web platform aiming to unite creators digitally. This platform serves as a hub for makers to connect and collaborate, while also offering a user-friendly interface for individuals seeking diverse products and services. It's a space where makers and enthusiasts seamlessly interact, facilitating collaboration and product discovery.

Enhancing security through energy alliance - A joint Action

The project has made significant contributions to better regional cooperation, people-to-people links, and reconciliation by fostering a sense of shared responsibility, providing practical solutions, establishing collaborative networks, and raising awareness about common challenges.

These efforts have not only improved relationships among Albania, Kosovo*, and North Macedonia but have also paved the way for more extensive regional cooperation. The establishment of a network of cooperation across these three countries further solidified the foundations of regional collaboration.

By connecting individuals, organizations, and institutions from different regions, the project has nurtured interpersonal relationships, trust, and mutual understanding. This network also created opportunities for future joint projects, thereby strengthening regional bonds.



Lead Applicant

Albanian Institute for International Studies | **Tiranë**

Partners

European Policy Institute (EPI) | **Skopje**
Democracy for Development (D4D) | **Prishtinë**

***This designation is without prejudice to positions on status, and is in line with UNSC 1244 and the ICJ Opinion on the Kosovo Declaration of Independence**

Folktronika: Re-imagining Balkan Folk Music through Technology



Lead Applicant
S.M.A.SH | **Prishtinë**

Partner
Jadro Social Cultural Space | **Skopje**
Society of Multimedial Artists for Secession and Humanities | **Prishtinë**
Destil Creative Hub | **Tiranë**

The "Lahuta" Album's unveiling was not just a musical release; it became a cultural milestone. Its meticulously curated tracks offered more than entertainment; they became true bearers of heritage, carrying stories and emotions passed down through generations.

The vinyl format, with its tangible presence, carried an essence of nostalgia, inviting listeners to not just hear but also feel the rhythms and melodies deeply ingrained in the region's cultural fabric.

Its impact went beyond borders, resonating with both connoisseurs of traditional music and newcomers eager to explore the roots of a rich musical tradition.

Future 4Roots

The Future4Roots project, through its activities, facilitated the exchange of culture, language, and traditions among different communities.

This helped participants better understand and appreciate diverse cultural perspectives and contributed to building connections among people.

This collaboration is likely to result in future joint initiatives and projects that serve common interests, which will undoubtedly aid in fostering understanding and resolving misunderstandings.

It was a project focused on the field of agriculture and made possible to reach many small stakeholders in remote places of our Region.



Lead Applicant
Agricultural Cluster SRP | **Istočno Sarajevo**

Partners
Agro-klastar Srbije | **Novi Sad**
Women Association Eva | **Rudo**
KUD Slavija | **Istočno Sarajevo**
Secondary School "28. juni" | **Istočno Sarajevo**
Association "Romanijski skorup-kajmak" | **Pijesak**
Association of mountain sports club RUEN | **Kriva Palanka**

Game Jam Prizren



Lead Applicant

IPKO Foundation | **Prishtinë**

Partner

Empower Society Albania (ESA Albania) |

Tiranë

Woman4Cyber North Macedonia | **Skopje**

Game Jam project brought together over 400 people, mixing experienced game makers with young talents.

These youngsters got the chance to team up and create a game together. The general goal was to encourage teamwork among regions and show how making games can bring people closer and help economies grow.

Game Jam provided lots of help to these young folks, supporting them in areas like making sure everyone feels included, understanding rights, treating everyone fairly no matter their gender, getting a good education, feeling empowered as young people, getting necessary services, and making sure minority groups feel valued.

Girls - the game changers of politics!

"Girls - Champions of Political Change" represents a significant milestone as it marks the establishment of exclusively young girls network in three of the Contracting Parties of the Western Balkans Fund.

Additionally, the inaugural implementation of a mentoring program by partner organizations in Tetovo and Tuzi added substantial value, ensuring the project's sustainability.

Moreover, the Academy conducted in Tuzi stands out as an invaluable addition. Its potential extends beyond the project's conclusion, serving as a potential model for ongoing Girls' political empowerment initiatives. This effort holds promise as a positive practice that can persist and thrive even after the project's completion.



Lead Applicant

Albanian Institute of Public Affairs - AIPA |

Tiranë

Partners

NGO "Djeca Crne Gore" | **Tuz**

Lifelong Learning Network | **Tetovo**

Improved inclusion at basic education in the WB through sharing of experiences



Lead Applicant
EdGuard | **Prishtinë**

Partner
Child Rights Centre Albania | **Tiranë**
Center for Education and Development |
Tearce

The project aimed to heighten awareness and comprehension of social and ecological resilience within the ecosystems of the Lake Ohrid watershed, specifically addressing climate and economic changes.

Emphasizing regional and cross-border cooperation in alignment with the European Green Agreements and the Balkan Green Agenda for Sustainable Community Development, the project partners achieved concrete outcomes.

Notably, they developed a comprehensive plan and guide containing eco-tourism management guidelines for the targeted region, a part of a protected area. Moreover, within the project area, the initiative facilitated the creation of ecotourism products and services

Interaction Teen Doc Workshop 2023 - Towards a Better Region

The project had a clear aim: to deepen young people's comprehension of regional cooperation, youth mobility, and intercultural learning. Its impact reverberated across the local communities and the wider region by harnessing the influence of documentary films.

These films became instrumental in enhancing media literacy among young individuals and served as catalysts in addressing historical narratives while shaping a collective vision for the future in the Western Balkans.

By uniting youth from various corners of the region and empowering them to explore creativity and expressiveness, the project significantly contributed to fostering increased mobility. It achieved this by presenting diverse perspectives and honing the film and media literacy skills of these young individuals.



Lead Applicant
Independent Film Centre "Filmart" | **Požega**

Partners
SEEcult.org Portal for SEE culture and art |
Beograd
Crnogorski filmski festival | **Podgorica**
Kinoklub Karlovac | **Karlovac**
Udruženje Produkcija Prvi kadar | **Istočno Sarajevo**
CSO Klara and Rosa | **Subotica**
Winter Apricot - Prilep | **Prilep**

Intercultural learning for all



Lead Applicant

Association "Halfway there" | **Pancevo**

Partners

SUMERO - Union of Organizations for Support to the Persons with intellectual disability of FBiH | **Sarajevo**

PORAKA - Republic Center for Support of Persons with Intellectual Disability | **Skopje**

People with intellectual disabilities (PwID), who used the organization's social services, learned about discrimination, tolerance, cultures, religions, and traditional foods. They also gained confidence in speaking in public, which helped them speak up for themselves.

The project's main achievement was making these individuals more aware of similar groups in neighboring regions. By the end, they realized they weren't alone and started understanding other countries' customs. This made them excited to visit new places and learn about different traditions.

Another big change was that after the project, these individuals felt confident in speaking publicly, giving them the ability to stand up for themselves.

Kids Classical Music Camp

The project's core goal was to unite children and teachers from diverse backgrounds, fostering connections through joint activities, performances, and lasting friendships.

It aimed to support personal growth by encouraging values like cultural sensitivity and mutual respect, evident in the participants' interactions and reflections.

Additionally, the project sought to advocate for classical music education within the regional context, engaging the local community through activities, a grand concert, and media coverage.

The collaborative effort among schools, music institutions, and NGOs created a strong network for ongoing support and future collaborations, leaving a lasting impact on the cultural landscape.



Lead Applicant

Association of Pianists and Music Pedagogues of Piano | **Bitola**

Partners

Udruzenje Sirmium Gradus ad Parnassum | **Sremska Mitrovica**

"Tefta Tashko Koço" High School | **Korçë**

Let's create music together



Lead Applicant

Municipal primary music school "Ordan Mihajloski-Ocka" | **Prilep**

Partners

Elementary music school "Davorin Jenko" –

Beograd

Public entity - School for elementary musical education "Istočno Sarajevo" | **Istočno**

Sarajevo

The project aimed to introduce professional teaching methods and tools to enhance the educational practices of the teaching staff while delving into diverse cultures through musical education, technical skills, and novel instrumental sounds.

Specifically, the goal was for the project to facilitate the exchange of experiences among participants regarding innovative, engaging teaching methods and tools. It aimed to foster the creation and testing of new learning tools applicable to daily interactions with students.

Moreover, the project sought to raise awareness about incorporating non-formal educational tools into formal lessons and highlight the advantages of non-formal learning methods.

Local Communities' Climate Adaptation and Resilience "LOCCAR"

For nine months, the LOCCAR project boosted the voices of three community groups in dealing with climate change.

By studying risks and creating helpful resources, it made people more aware of how climate change affects their areas. Most importantly, it brought more people into the decision-making process for climate plans, aligning with EU strategies.

LOCCAR stands as a powerful example of communities working together to prepare for a changing climate.

The LOCCAR Project met these needs through various outcomes, like creating and sharing publications, educational content on social media, and hosting regional round table discussions.



Lead Applicant

Centre for Climate Change, Natural Resources and Energy of University of Donja Gorica | **Podgorica**

Partners

Regional Environmental Center | **Sarajevo**

Environmental Ambassadors for Sustainable Development | **Beograd**

Miredita, Dobar dan!



Lead Applicant

Youth Initiative for Human Rights Serbia | **Beograd**

Partners

Inicijativa mladih za ljudska prava u BiH |

Sarajevo

Integra | **Prishtinë**

Civic Initiatives | **Beograd**

The project left a lasting impact on the partners, fostering a deeper understanding and appreciation of each other's work, target groups, capacities, and commitments in their respective countries.

This mutual recognition has set the stage for future partnerships among the partners, creating a solid foundation for ongoing cooperation.

Furthermore, the project's influence extends to younger generations, providing them with a stable and engaged framework for their future endeavors.

Moreover, the formulation and endorsement of the position paper played a pivotal role in strengthening shared responsibility among the partners.

Open Western Balkan Collaboratory on Online Platform Work

The project set up a strong base for future sustainability through a long-running COST PWILL action that lasted until 2026. This effort involved all partners working on policies to include gender equality and marginalized communities in EU rules for platform work. This practical approach aimed to make lasting changes in the online platform job world.

In 2024, the Center teamed up with another European initiative called "Reshaping Work." They brought together folks from universities, businesses, governments, and community groups to talk about European rules for platform jobs and similar EU plans.

They organized a big meeting in Belgrade (April 17, 18) that welcomed about 100 people from Southeast Europe and beyond. The main focus was on platform jobs.



Lead Applicant

Public Policy Research Centre | **Beograd**

Partners

University of Shkodra "Luigj Gurakuqi" |

Shkodër

Association for social, cultural and creative development Zora | **Zenica**

People to People - In Music We Trust



Lead Applicant

Social Contract Institute | **Tiranë**

Partners

Odjek Chamber Choir | **Požarevac**

Pro Ars Choir | **Skopje**

The SCI proposal aligned with the primary objective of the WBF, aiming to strengthen cooperation among Western Balkan Contracting Parties while promoting shared values between local authorities, citizens, and Civil Society Organizations (CSOs).

Positioned within the call's thematic area of Cultural Cooperation, the project focused on crucial crosscutting issues like gender equality and the protection and promotion of ethnic minority rights, emphasizing their involvement in decision-making processes and fostering people-to-people connections.

Building on the successful approach of the previous "Balkan Girl Power" project, this proposal sought to unite people in the Western Balkans by advocating for common values.

Promoting Collaboration Between SMEs and Civil Society in the Fight Against Corruption

The project's main findings provide a clear picture of corruption and the spheres that require more attention from civil society, the government or anyone who is interested to make a change, in a local level context, on all three of the cities that were analysed.

It opened the road for further cooperation between the project partners and even further, countries due to their similar nature.

The activities and promotion of the project aimed to raise the findings even further so that they could go in the ears of policy makers and all partners have worked really hard to spread the findings all over their local media outlets.



Lead Applicant

Albanian Center for Economic Research (ACER) | **Tiranë**

Partners

Institute for Corruption Research KAREYAS |

Pancevo

Organization for Democracy, Anti-Corruption and Dignity – ÇOHU! | **Prishtinë**

Regional cooperation of scientists and young researchers from the Western Balkans in the field of mammalian ecology

Lead Applicant

Ecology and Research Association (EID) |
Banja Luka

Partner

CESI | **Zagreb**
NGO Prima | **Podgorica**
Alternative Girl's Center | **Krusevac**
Macedonian Ecological Society (MES) | **Skopje**
Faculty of Sciences, University of Novi Sad (FSUNS) | **Novi Sad**
Wildlife Montenegro (WLMNE) | **Kotor**
Center for Karst and Speleology (CKS) |
Sarajevo
The Mammal Society (TMSBIH) | **Ilidža**

Through collaborations with global and European entities like IUCN and the European Mammal Foundation, it became evident that the Western Balkan Contracting Parties lacked comprehensive data on their biodiversity, as well as the requisite expertise.

Recognizing these substantial gaps in capacity building, data collection, and the protection of mammalian biodiversity, the decision was made to address these deficiencies.

The approach involved assembling the most proficient experts from the WB6 countries, fostering their collaboration, and sharing their collective knowledge and experiences. The project focused on leveraging the expertise of these professionals to educate young researchers, initiating efforts to enhance the professional capacity within the Western Balkans.

Regional empowerment of women – promotion and protection of traditional artisan products

The project aimed to strengthen collaboration, foster relationships among people, and promote harmony in the region. To achieve this, women from three Contracting Parties were brought together.

These women, from diverse backgrounds, had the opportunity to meet and interact. Through these interactions, they formed a cohesive group, which served as a platform for ongoing cooperation and joint endeavors.

By forming strong bonds within their group, they aimed to establish connections beyond, reaching out to other individuals and communities.

Their vision extended beyond personal empowerment; it aimed to enhance the lives of all women within their respective regions.



YOUTUBE.COM

Regional empowerment of women – promotion and protection of traditional artisan products project

Lead Applicant

NVO Equality | **Prizren**

Partners

Association “Pazarski Bazar Rukotvorina” Novi Pazar | **Novi Pazar**
Center “Women in Public Service” | **Tiranë**

Regional youth festival “Little Night Music”



Lead Applicant

City of Kragujevac | **Kragujevac**

Partners

Municipality of Bar | **Bar**

Municipality of Foča | **Foča**

Municipality of Ohrid | **Ohrid**

The project "Little Night Music" was guided by a compelling vision: enhancing youth involvement in culture while supporting regional intercultural dialogue. Its primary goal was to bolster regional cooperation and unity within the WB6 Region.

This objective was successfully realized through active participation and collaboration among young artists from the WB6. Their joint involvement in cultural and artistic events, alongside specialized training in the field of culture, were crucial in achieving this goal.

The unique cooperation established by four administrative units in four different Contracting Party, is another big asset of this project.

Research Station International Summer School

The implementation of the project led to the realization of the originally set goals: popularization of science, increase in the level of scientific literacy and encouragement of young people to devote themselves to scientific research work.

Thirty of the most talented students from Montenegro, Serbia and North Macedonia were given the opportunity to engage in practical work, conduct experiments and thus learn about the most interesting mathematics, physics, chemistry, biology, medicine, electronics and astronomy.

The participants came into contact with lecturers from the country and abroad, who explained numerous scientific phenomena to them through interactive lectures.



Lead Applicant

Montenegrin Science Promotion Foundation
"PRONA" | **Podgorica**

Partners

NGO Osvezenje | **Pirot**

GAUSS Institute – Foundation for New Technologies, Innovations, and Knowledge Transfer | **Bitola**

Reversing the brain drain through the Scientific Diaspora in the Western Balkans



Lead Applicant
RRGSH | **Skopje**

Partners

Institute for Strategic Studies and Prognoses |
Podgorica
GERMIN | **Prishtinë**
Center for Economic and Social Studies (CESS)
| **Tiranë**

The project connected various groups and institutions beyond the ones officially involved. Through a large Conference about migration in the area, the project united different research groups and people who make decisions from all over.

Specifically, the meetings gathered university researchers from places all the Contracting Parties of the Western Balkans Fund. It also included policymakers, people from communities, and the media. This meeting didn't just add something new to the study of migration, but it also gave important suggestions for leaders in the Region.

Say and Do Green!

“Public spaces often blend into the backdrop of daily life, yet they form the canvas upon which countless stories unfold”. According to SEDA, within these spaces, individuals navigate their thoughts and aspirations, seeking avenues to connect and express themselves.

Drawing inspiration from the universal right to freely express thoughts and ideas, and inspired by projects such as Candy Cheng's, an initiative was launched to offer a platform for individuals across North Macedonia, Albania, and Montenegro to openly share their perspectives on environmental and climate issues.

While sustainability and environmental concerns have gained widespread attention, there remains a gap in public understanding. This initiative aimed to bridge that gap by providing individuals a voice to articulate their awareness and willingness to engage in environmental action.



Lead Applicant
Sustainable Economic Development Agency (SEDA) | **Tiranë**

Partner

Ecological Network of Montenegro | **Bar**
Institute for Good Governance and Policy in Environment and Climate Change (IPECC) |
Skopje

Solar energy for citizens in Western Balkans



Lead Applicant

Friends of Korça | **Korçë**

Partners

Tirana Politechnic University | **Tiranë**

Albanian Association of Renewable Energy (AREA) | **Tiranë**

Korça University | **Korçë**

Balkan WASH Network (BWN) | **Skopje**

Fond za Inovacije Cerne Gore (FICG) | **Podgorica**

CSCD | **Debar**

MSJA | **Ulcinj**

Environmental Ambassadors for Sustainable Development (EASD) | **Beograd**

The Western Balkans has faced big challenges from climate change, relying a lot on coal and not-so-clean energy. To fix this, people needed to switch to cleaner energy and get everyone involved.

While almost all of the EU saw climate change as a serious issue (93%), only about two-thirds of the Western Balkans thought the same way in a 2019 survey. To help everyone understand and get involved, the "Friends of Korca" Association teamed up with partners in the region.

Their plan was simple: spread the word about solar energy by creating the WB-SolarNet website. This platform brought together groups that care about the environment. It was a way to tell leaders in the Western Balkans that using solar power could be a big help in building a greener and more sustainable economy for the region.

Summer School for Future (STE)M leaders

The Consortium focused on the pressing issue of STEM education and the shared challenge of a shortage of qualified math and computer science instructors in our region.

A school program was devised to facilitate extensive interaction between students and speakers from partner countries in the serene town of Petrovac. This setting not only provided an environment for learning but also allowed participants to unwind by enjoying the sea and beach during their free time.

The school's approach wasn't confined to traditional classroom settings; it extended to outdoor workshops designed as cultural expeditions. These excursions served as a gateway to acquainting participants with Montenegro's diverse cultural and religious heritage.

Lead Applicant

University of Montenegro, Faculty of Mathematics and Natural Sciences | **Podgorica**

Partners

Universiteti "Ismail Qemali" | **Vlorë**
Mathematical Institute of the Serbian Academy | **Beograd**

of Sciences and Arts | **Beograd**
University of East Sarajevo, Faculty of Production and Management | **Istočno Sarajevo**

University of Mostar, Faculty of Natural and Educational Sciences | **Mostar**
Ss Cyril and Methodius University, Faculty of Natural Sciences and Mathematics | **Skopje**

Tailoring the Future for Women in WB Region



Lead Applicant

Shoqata Bardha | **Prishtinë**

Partners

Trade Association Textile Cluster | **Skopje**
Center for Excellence Destiny | **Tiranë**

The project, "Tailoring the Future for Women in WB Region," stood on three key pillars. The first involved directly engaging 60 marginalized women from the three Contracting Parties.

Pillar two focused on tailored training modules designed from a needs assessment. The third pillar centered on training participants in sewing and entrepreneurship skills.

Finally, the fourth pillar successfully promoted these entrepreneurial skills to potential investors at a regional conference organized by the partners, creating opportunities for the women involved.

Talk with me

Thanks to the EU-WBF Joint Grant, the partners were able to revive the successful platform, shendetimentor.org, impacting a substantial number of individuals.

The direct services provided through the chat benefited up to 1,500 youngsters, while an additional 3,000 individuals received assistance through platform visits.

The platform's revival sparked immense interest, leading to the commitment of 60 trained volunteers to offer online counseling, surpassing the initial plan of 25 volunteers.

This increased capacity enables a broader reach and enhanced support for those seeking guidance and assistance through the platform's resources.



Lead Applicant

Center for Global Health | **Prishtinë**

Partners

Qendra per Kerkim Implementim | **Tiranë**
Projektesh (R.I.C.P)
Synopsis World | **Skopje**

WB cities creating more opportunities for young people



Lead Applicant

LDA Subotica | **Subotica**

Partners

Local Democracy Agency Montenegro

| **Podgorica**

Local Democracy Agency Montenegro

| **Prijedor**

The project was developed by partners to raise awareness, build capacities, and initiate local actions involving youth groups from three cities.

Its primary aim was to empower grassroots youth, young artists, IT clusters, and youth workers by promoting creative industries and entrepreneurship.

The project's core idea was rooted in contemporary cultural trends and the evolution of creative industries. It sought to merge creativity, entrepreneurship, and cultural engagement, particularly focusing on involving diverse groups, especially young individuals, in cultural participation.

"We are creating a better future"

Creating a better future in the Western Balkans is a journey that demands patience and effort. It's a process of gradually building trust among communities and embracing the richness that comes with diversity. Instead of seeing differences as obstacles, we recognize them as valuable assets that enrich our lives.

In the project's various activities, particularly during the student camp, something remarkable happened. Teachers and students had the chance to collaborate and mingle with peers from a different country for the very first time.

Surprisingly, when we conducted a survey, it revealed that a staggering 90% of students hadn't ventured beyond their own country's borders within the Western Balkans, despite these countries being part of our project.



Lead Applicant

Public Institution Secondary Technical School

| **Tešanj**

Partners

Technical school | **Čačak**

Mixed secondary school "Mladost" | **Tivat**

West Balkan Handball Youth Cup



Lead Applicant

ORK Borac | **Banja Luka**

Partners

RK Gračanica | **Gračanica**

RK Crvena Zvezda | **Beograd**

RK Lovćen | **Cetinje**

The Cup's core mission of fostering unity among children from diverse backgrounds was palpable throughout the three-day tournament in Banja Luka.

Witnessing these youngsters engage, interact, and compete without distinctions based on nationality or religion was a powerful testament to the potential of sports in promoting inclusivity.

Beyond the competitive spirit, the event served as a platform for mutual understanding and respect, highlighting the commonalities that bind us as humans despite our differences.

This collective experience not only promoted sportsmanship but also laid the groundwork for lasting friendships and a shared sense of community among the participants.

Western Balkan Ideathon

The project had a few main goals. First, it aimed to bring three CSOs (Foundation 787, Digital Den, and Association of Young Entrepreneurs Serbia) together.

They all helped young and female entrepreneurs in their countries but hadn't worked together before. This project let them team up, making their connections stronger and finding more ways to work together.

Another goal was to help young people get involved in making their countries' economies better. These countries have lots of talented young people, but they don't always get the chance to show what they can do.

By working together across different countries, everyone could share their ideas and come up with solutions that would help the region. This also created a space for promoting new business ideas and encouraging innovative ways of starting businesses based on knowledge.



Lead Applicant

Foundation 787 | **Sarajevo**

Partners

Digital Den| G. | **Podgorica**

Association of Young Entrepreneurs of Serbia| **Beograd**

Youth KULT Zone



Lead Applicant

Youth Alliance - Krusevo | **Krusevo**

Partners

Young Professionals Network | **Tiranë**
P.S. "MAYA"- Educational Center | **Travnik**
Center for Education and Training | **Prizren**
Tim za Razvoj i Integracije | **Vranje**
Youth Cultural Centre | **Herceg Novi**

The 'Youth Kult Zone' project aimed to bring different cultures together in the Western Balkans using digital media. It was made by six groups that focus on young people and society.

Their plan was to get young folks talking about different cultures to help the region work together better, which matched what the EU/WBF wanted to see. Surprisingly, 'Youth KULT Zone' did even better than expected, reaching and affecting over 3000 young people in the Western Balkans.

This showed that new and team-based ways of doing things are really needed in the area. To make the project's goals happen, they achieved the following things:

Green cohesion and Sustainable Tourism in the basin of Lake Ohrid

The project aimed to heighten awareness and comprehension of social and ecological resilience within the ecosystems of the Lake Ohrid watershed, specifically addressing climate and economic changes.

Emphasizing regional and cross-border cooperation in alignment with the European Green Agreements and the Balkan Green Agenda for Sustainable Community Development, the project partners achieved concrete outcomes.

Notably, they developed a comprehensive plan and guide containing eco-tourism management guidelines for the targeted region, a part of a protected area. Moreover, within the project area, the initiative facilitated the creation of ecotourism products and services



Lead Applicant

ORTET - Organization for rural tourism, ecology and tradition | **Ohrid**

Partners

New Impact | **Pogradec**
Balkania - Balkan Association for Alternative Tourism | **Skopje**
Association Licej | **Belgrade**

Our Stories



Lead Applicant

The Association of Women Sandglass | **Krusevac**

Partners

Mitrovica Women Association for Human Rights | **Mitrovica**
Vatra Psycho-Social Center | **Vlorë**

Three women's groups from three Contracting Parties teamed up for a special project.

Their partnership is all about something simple yet powerful: they believe that sharing personal stories can change things in big ways.

These stories are becoming a part of how people remember things, shaping society and how we think about important issues.

Their goal was to make a difference by showing that every story matters, and when we share them, it can change how we understand our world. This project isn't just about them; it's about making a lasting impact on how people see each other and how society grows.

UProot Gender Based Violence (GBV)

The project brought together four Contracting Parties. Their goal was to work together, share experiences, and tackle issues like preventing gender-based violence, supporting youth, collaborating with institutions, and involving civil society.

The partners organized visits, meetings, and an online campaign. These activities showed how countries can cooperate, reconcile, and better understand the difficulties women face in society.

Through joint efforts, this project created a space for these four countries to learn from each other. They shared ideas on preventing gender-based violence, supporting young people, and collaborating with different organizations. By coming together for events and discussions, they showed how teamwork and understanding can make a positive impact on how societies address the challenges women encounter.



Lead Applicant

Fondacija CURE | **Sarajevo**

Partners

CESI | **Zagreb**
NGO Prima | **Podgorica**
Alternative Girl's Center | **Krusevac**

WBF-EU First Call for Proposals

WBF launched the First Call for Proposals of the Joint Action on November 8th 2021. Applications remained open until December 27th.

As usual, it encompassed three main areas of intervention: cultural cooperation, education and scientific exchanges, and sustainable development.

The full report of the 1 CFP is available for free download on the official webpage of the Western Balkans Fund (documents section).

In this and the following few pages, you will find a short information about all the projects supported in the framework of 1 CFP.

In total, there were 30 winners, with 128 stakeholders included, from a total of 207 eligible applications.

With the key areas of support, education and research, culture and sustainable development, applicants had a chance to explore and propose regional initiatives addressing one of the cross-cutting issues that included gender mainstreaming, equal opportunities, the empowerment of minorities and vulnerable groups, environmental sustainability, climate change mitigation and adaptation, and more.

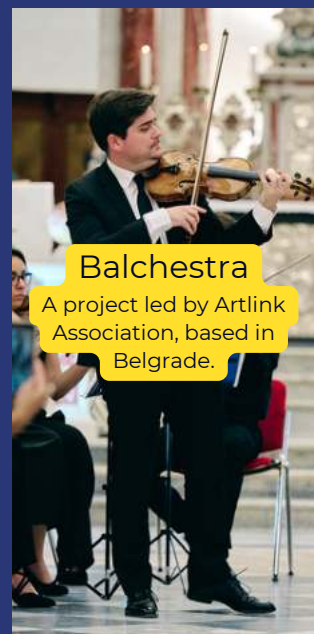
WBF announced winners in March 2022 and celebrated the success of this Call with 30 regional grant winners from the Region on 14-15 April 2022 in Tirana with the Award Ceremony and Partnership Workshop.

Immediately after the start of the implementation phase of the 4 CFP in April, the Fund prepared and successfully launched the most prominent Call for Proposals of its history, the 5th Call for Proposals, awarding 39 regional grants to over 130 Civil Society Organisations. More detailed information about 2 CFP in the next chapter.



Art for Reconciliation

A project led by Tulla Culture Center in Tiranë



Balchestra

A project led by Artlink Association, based in Belgrade.



Balkan Shorts Film Network

A project led by UG Akademiska Scena in Bajina Basta.



Bird's Without Borders

A project led by "CZIP", based in Spuz.



Common Cultural Heritage: Interregional Research and educational practices

A project led by Center for Prehistoric Research in Skopje



Creating a Cross-Border Network for socio-economic sustainability

A project led by FLAG Association in Tirana



Contemporary Fortresses of Culture

A project led by Don Branko Sbutega Foundation, based in Kotor



Cross-Border co-working cooperation

A project led by Intera Technological Park in Mostar



Enhancing Regional Cooperation of Young Researchers on Migration

A project led by GERMIN, based in Prishtina



Female Leadership Camp

A project led by Fun Schools Association based in Sarajevo.



Game Jam

A project led by IPKO Foundation in Prishtina.



Hello Neighbour

A project led by Impact Centre in Tirana.



I Love Balkan

A project led by NGO Lady, based in Prishtina.



In Search of Our Musical Roots

A project led by Jazz Art Association, based in Podgorica.



Intercultural Dialogue for Joint Past narrative and Reconciliation

A project led by Youth Initiative for Human Rights Montenegro, based in Podgorica



Intercultural Dialogue: A tool for youth to youth connection

A project led by Albanian Foundation for Conflict Resolution and Reconciliation of Disputes in Tirana



Leap to Success

A project led by AGORA Organisation in Skopje.



Mainstreaming Humanity in the Western Balkans

A project led by Faculty of Political Sciences, University of Belgrade.



Media and Art in service of Reconciliation

A project led by "Kulturanova", based in Petrovaradin, Novi Sad



Messages from the past

A project led by Zenica City Museum in Zenica



Partnership for Mother and Babies

A project led by "Gadjanski Glas Montenegro", based in Budva.



Promoting the Western Balkans greenways

A project led by YUGO Cycling, based in Belgrade.



Protection of Natural and Cultural Heritage

A project led by Stena Stenae, based in Demir Kapija.



Regional Evenings of cultural heritage

A project led by the Ensemble of folk dances and songs "Veselin Maslesa" in Banja Luka.



Regional Investment Promotion

A project led by Chamber of Trade and Industry of Kosovo, with centre in Prishtina.



Support to Women's effort in building regional democracy

A project led by Kosovo Institute of Media and Communication.



The Green Valley

A project led by IPSIA BiH, based in Sarajevo.



Ohrid Trcat Athletic Club

A project led by Athletic Club Ohrid Trcat in Ohrid. o.



Youth Artisanal Centre

A project led by Association Tirana Ekspres.



Strengthening intercultural dialogue as a tool for youth-to-youth connection

A project led by Albanian Foundation for Conflict Resolution and Reconciliation of Disputes in Tirana.



Our success story continues

The EU-WBF Joint Action has been a success. This is not only what we believe, but also what Brussels' underlined in the recent assessment of our Fund.

Thanks to the many achievements, we are now delighted to share that the shared Joint Action will continue benefiting Civil Society Organization's and stakeholders in our region for the next two years (2024-25).

Recognizing the regional impact of this grant scheme, talks for the extension of the Joint Action with the European Union began in the early summer 2023. Following successful negotiations, the contract for the extension was signed last month by both parties—the European Commission and the Western Balkans Fund.

With the launch of the new phase, we aim to introduce an even more successful and engaging mechanism to support civil society organization's. The new mechanism, named the “Empowering Regional Cooperation Grants” (ERC Grants), will boast the largest portfolio ever allocated to CSOs in the region, doubling the current maximum threshold of 15,000 Euros per grant.

The upcoming 2024-25 Joint Action will comprise two main components. Firstly, direct financial support through grant schemes launched respectively in Spring 24' and Autumn 24'. Secondly, Capacity development activities on a Regional Scale to support CSOs and grass-root organizations on Applying, Implementing and Reporting on Regional Projects

DISCLAIMER

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This publication is the sole responsibility of the Western Balkans Fund Secretariat and in no way can be taken to necessarily reflect the views of the European Union or WBF Contracting Parties.



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